of the countryside. In Switzerland, I got my first watch—a Fortis, automatic with date—which I used till I bought an HMT Quartz in 1983 from the unit-run canteen, which I still wear today, forty years later. We did the stretch from Vienna to Paris in our Fiat car, a distance of almost a thousand kilometres in less than a day, so good were the autoroutes even in those days, touching 100 kmph quite easily. That car remained with us till the late 1990s for almost thirty years as it came back with us to India. It was a good thing too, because once, on the Chandigarh-Ambala highway, we met with an accident when a bus side-swiped us and the car went tumbling. There were no seat belts or airbags in those days, yet all of us crawled out without even a scratch. Providence.

These travels and the experiences we had shaped my personality in different ways. We got to know of different cultures and languages, accepting and enjoying this diversity. In later years, the concept of 'Unity in Diversity' was so much easier to comprehend, considering each state in India too has its own customs, traditions, language and cuisine. Equally, the value of fine workmanship, whether a watch or car or exquisite pieces of art. Many years later, in one of the school lessons, there was a chapter on Michelangelo, with his quote, 'Trifles make perfection, and perfection is no trifle.' I could appreciate that sentiment, having seen those masterpieces first-hand. It also made me familiar with many different places and names, so that in later years, when I would come across them, it all sounded familiar. This was particularly true in my reading of military history because, in my mind's eye, I could visualize the terrain and weather being referred to. Travel is education, provided one keeps an open mind.

Soon it was time to return to India. In 1967, Israel and Egypt fought a six-day war. There was an Israeli family in our

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